Because I am Furniture

By Thalia Chaltas

I am always there.
But they don't care if I am
because I am furniture.

I don't get hit
I don't get fondled I
don't get love
because I am furniture.

Suits me fine. (pg 3)

INTRODUCTION

We often hear stories from the perspective of those who are abused, but what does it feel like to be the one child in the family who is ignored, forgotten, and left feeling powerless to help the ones you love? What is it like to have no voice? Anke is the youngest of three siblings. Welcome to her life of silence . . . and bear witness . . . Because I am Furniture by Thalia Chaltas

Quiet and earnest,
he is squatting in front of me.
I hunch on the couch.

"I know you think you want to play volleyball.
--- *aren't I already?*

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Competition creates
a false sense of empowerment,
an I'm better than you euphoria
believe me. I know.
I wouldn't want you to get caught up in that,
the hunger for control over others.
When I was young blah blah blah blah

My eyes watch his thin lips moving against
each other in silence,
and I know
that Darren and Yaicha were right
when they once used our father to teach me the
meaning of the word
hypocrite. (Page 51-52)

Dinner.

He knocked Darren onto the linoleum.

I don't remember his arm swing,
just Darren and his chair --
eight tangled limbs on the floor.

No reason that I could see.

But my father picked up his reasons and his
plate and went
to eat
in the living room.

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Darren picked up his chair and himself and we are
now eating
in customary ice-age silence. (pg 5)

His Anger stands alone
stands erect
in the
middle of the room.

We step gently around it,
a terrifying totem pole
bristling beaks, pinions, talons.

I can't remember
when it started
when firm hand
became
fisted liege
became
feral
tyrannical
rage
more important than
the rest of us,
but
it didn't used to be this way
and that
keeps us tied to him,
guessing,
teetering,
waiting,

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while stepping around
his Anger
in the
middle of the room. (125-126)

He's losing it bad tonight,
the second time this week,
chasing Yaicha out of the kitchen
holding his chair over her head-

she cowers on the living room rug.

I am close behind mom,
but it's not like I can ever do anything.

No one sees me.

Mom gets him to stop,
with taut and twisted face, open hands,
before the chair comes down.

Yaicha runs.

He sits down, tired,
and says to mom,
"I'm sorry you had to see that."

Inevitable that he does it.

But he doesn't really want
a witness. (page 19-20)

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My Father,
Who Art Not in Heaven,
and never will be,
sometimes
doesn't come home
from work
until two a.m.

and for his own reasons
goes to my sister's room

before he goes
to his own bed.

I don't want to
hear
know
live here.

I am scared for her
but I am so glad
he doesn't

come to my room. (Page 39-40)

Little packet by Yaicha's bed

I've seen them before--
Marci takes the pill before school
laughing in the girls' room,

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proof of her
extracurricular
activities

But I overheard Yaicha tell her friend
she's a virgin,

never even had a boyfriend,

so I don't get it.

And she storms in
snatches the packet
raging about privacy.

Bubbling panic
I go on the offensive –

"Why should *you* take the pill?"

My insides shred
as she glares a full minute

and I stand my ground
wanting her to tell me
tell me
anything,

but when I see pain
forming
on her retinas

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I decide I don't want to know.
I run. (109-110)

I mean,
WHY can't she just tell on him?
It's just words.

Just
open her mouth
and out come those words.

And then he'd be stopped.

Right? (pg 163)

Darren came into the kitchen
this morning,
black circles
around wavering eyes,
and he wouldn't look at any of us.

Mom said he was sick

but he's not sick.
I've seen this
a few times before

always after he and my father fight

and then

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my father "talks" to him
in private

in his room
for hours

but most of the time
I don't hear their voices (page 146-147)

Why am I not good enough?

At least he loves
Darren and Yaicha
in some way

even if it's horrible,
he shows them attention

and I am furniture
I get nothing
nothing
nothing
no
thing

or
at times I get
a knife-edge glimpse of
something scary.

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I think that it is supposed to be good,
that I get less
from him

but I feel . . .
worth
less. (105-106)

. . . and i'm jealous!
with a sick
acidic
burbling
bile
i want what they have

as horrible
curdling
vile
as it is
darren and yaicha get more
than
me. (pg 235)

Yanking jeans over sweaty skin,
I come out of my room,
Darren comes up the stairs,
and our father comes from the bathroom,
        a damp bath towel dangling
        from forefinger and thumb.

"Whose." he intones at me in the hallway,

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"is this?"

Darren holds out his hand.
"Mine," he whispers.

Our father looks surprised.
Did he think it was mine?

He breathes in,
launches the offensive at Darren.
"HOW MANY TIMES HAVE I TOLD YOU TO
  HANG THIS ... "
louder and louder
words crushing together
in a piling roar
"YOU THINK YOU CAN JUST DO WHAT YOU
   WANT ... "
"I AM THE ONE WHO KNOWS WHAT'S GOOD
   FOR YOU ... "

I want to make him turn to me
yell at *me*

I want to yell at *him*
        I am here
        right here
        I am not furniture --

But when his hand
smothers Darren's face with the wet towel,
shoving him hard into the wall,

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I am backing away. (177-179)

Yaicha is crying gently
in the bathroom. (pg 231)

It just occurred to me.

It's her choice.
Yaicha chooses not to tell anyone
and Darren does too
and Mom.

Am I the only one bothered by this?
I mean
bothered enough to think about it?

So all the pressure is on me,
the Youngest and Most Bothered.
Or maybe I am just
outside enough,
being the footstool observing from the corner,
that I have a view of reality.

And I can't stand it anymore.

Why me?
I don't need this crap

Then

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why don't I tell on him?

If they don't,
why don't I?
Because.

Because I am safe this way,
silent
unnoticed.

Because my family would crack
snap
shatter
like pine boughs in an ice storm
jagged pieces scattered,
irreparable,

and there would be no family
and I don't want that on my head.

What we have is better than that.

Right? (239-240)

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TRANSITION

Confusion, feelings of worthlessness, fear . . . such strong feelings can only be locked inside for so long. A catalyst is all that is needed to force these emotions to the surface – It is then that the "furniture" finds a voice - - A branch can bend only so far before it breaks . . . And once Anke develops a friendship outside her family, Angeline becomes that catalyst and Anke finds her voice.

"Your father must have
info like that."
Angeline is at me
again.

Mom is making me work with her
on topics for government

"He must have
books and books,"
Angie is pleading.
"He's a professor."

I'm not asking
him
for anything.

I want to say,
Get over your goddamn crush,
Angie,
you have no idea

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who he is.
But my jaws
clamp.

" I'll call him."
she offers.

Well why not?
She's already more a part of my family
than I am. (266-267)

I am annoyed
when Angeline comes,
clutching her pale pink sweater,
breathlessly spilling
that we could pick up government law info
at my father's office.

"He said 'Sure'" she squeals.
He'll leave a folder on his desk because,
sigh,
"he might have a meeting."
She is is briefly bereft.

I say I'll meet her in the lobby

"Oh, I told him I'd go, I don't mind."

Grrrr.
He *is* my father.
"No, I'll meet you," I throw at her

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retreating back
but she's gone.

"Why don't you just frickin' move in with us,"
I say out loud.

I'll be glad when this government thing is over,
this annoying extracurricular supposed honor
that forces me to spend
even more time
with Angeline. (300 - 301)

I'm a little late
getting to my father's building.

I scan for Angeline in the lobby
then sprint up the three flights.
Coming to the DR. LARUS FELD etched on his
frosted door,
Tapping lightly,
turning the knob,
the door swings in silence, fangs of light
glinting in the glass.

Then I hear --
I hear something soft crying somewhere.

Angeline?

Sneakers on carpet,
carpet,

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carpet,
lean around the bookcase. –

My
father with a small smile
leaning toward the armchair,
zipper on its way clown,
Angeline, her skirt tweaked,
swelling closing one eye,
pleading softly, no, no.

"NO!"
Dr. Feld is shock still.
I take another lungful,
"NO!"
Angie slides to standing,
gathering her book bag,
running for the exit.
Raising brows, he mocks me,
but, dammit, he will hear me,

"NO!"

Slamming by the bookcase
tearing through the doorway
pounding down the stairwell,
no-no-no-no,
NO--NO--NO. (302-304)

By the brook

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with a crunch of fine ice,
I double over,
dry heaves
on my knees.

What did I see?
What did I see in his office?

How could he, to
poor Angeline?

I sink onto a rock near the water,
taking a blood-red
maple leaf
and dunking it under,
holding it beneath the frigid liquid.

Poor Angie.

She was supposed to be outside our
house of horrors
and I let her in.
I should have kept her away from him.
He went outside.

And the tears burst through
heavy as mercury,
heated by guilt,
and I take the leaf out of the water,
sobbing.

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Angeline,
Angie,
I'm sorry (306-307)

Pushing open the bathroom door
I take two steps toward Yaicha
who is wrestling with her hair.

"I saw him hurt Angeline."

The brush stops moving.

"At his office today."
Small sounds
like a dying cricket
come from Yaicha's lips.
"I'm sure you were mistaken." she says
to her brush.
"MISTAKEN?
I know who Angie is, Yaicha.
I know who our father is, Yaicha.
He hurts people, he hurts you,

you never do anything!"
My claws scrape the wall paint.

She turns with soft rabbit eyes.
"He'll kill me."

"He's already doing that!"
I am growling, grabbing her sleeve,

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"Every day,
every day he rips you open,
chips off pieces week by week,
till a few years from now you are not even a
  mouthful of sawdust.
A drawn-out killing.
Well, I'm tired of all of us doing nothing.
He has to be stopped."

Yaicha's eyes have flinched a few times
but soften again.
"Nobody can stop him."

"Nobody can stop him?
Good.
To him I have always been
Nobody." (311 - 313)

They all swivel to me --
Mom, Darren, and Yaicha --

Footfall,
Darren frozen, eyes on the baseboard,
Yaicha melted against the stereo cabinet,
as he steps lightly up the stairs.

"Sorry I couldn't give you
a ride home,"
he says to me,
sliding into the living room
with his briefcase,

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"I had a meeting."

His eyes dare me.
Dare me. (319-320)

Slow motion
twitching
twitching
hissing burning
blood pushing
itching skin
pushing out
something scary
pushing out something stronger.
(321)

I stand behind his chair.
"Liar,"
under my breath.

His eyebrows rise,
pupils sharpen.

"You weren't at a meeting,"
take a breath, gain speed, bursting,
"You were with Angie in the office.
I saw you. I saw you.
You clamp us down,
you think no one knows.
You hurt my brother! My sister!

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You hurt my friend! Small trusting prey, huh?
You could have chosen to hurt me!

But I'm not worth enough I never am
and you picked poor Angie,
you were going to RAPE her,
I SAW YOU TRY TO RAPE ANGIE,
you f***ing MONSTER!"

I shove his chair forward
with the force of my words,
the wooden leg touches
his foot.

Stillness. Shaking.

White-faced, cold,
slowly
he picks it up by the seat.

Suddenly spinning the chair in air
he smashes it on me
hard –

with a great crack
I go down,
splinters of wood
splinters of bone
my leg showing bone,

and finally

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I
roar. (322-323)

Where is the safe, cuddling daddy
who
sang "I'm Being Swallowed by a Boa
Constrictor" to me
when I had a fever?

Was that man molted off
like scales that no longer
lie smoothly
around the shape of what he has become?

I want my daddy back.

Too bad for me. (316)

He's been arrested.

In jail.

Such an odd disconnect

to feel so relieved
and so guilty,

yet so cold about the whole thing,
like concrete,
like a nuclear reactor decommissioned

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and left by itself to withstand the
winter.

I wonder if he has to wear one of those
bar-striped suits. (329)

I did it.
I filed
a restraining order
against
my own father.

He's out on bail
and needs more than restraining.

But it's
a damn good
start,
and
I did it. (331-332)

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AWARD HISTORY

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